TRANCE

TRANCE is a state of altered consciousness where a person becomes deeply absorbed and highly focused, often losing awareness of their surroundings. In this state, the mind is more open to suggestions and can access deeper levels of thought and feeling. Trance can occur naturally, like when daydreaming or being engrossed in a book or movie, but it is also induced intentionally in practices like hypnosis and meditation. During trance, the brain's activity changes, leading to a sense of calm and heightened inner awareness. This state is often used for therapeutic purposes, such as hypnotherapy, to help individuals access and work through subconscious thoughts and emotions. It can also enhance creativity, problem-solving, and personal insight, making it a valuable tool for self-improvement and healing.

General State: Trance is a broad term that refers to any state of focused attention and altered consciousness. This can happen naturally, such as when you're deeply

engrossed in a book, daydreaming, or lost in thought.

Self-Induced or Spontaneous: Trance can occur spontaneously or be self-induced through practices like meditation, rhythmic dancing, or chanting.

Variety of Experiences: There are various forms of trance, including those experienced in spiritual or religious rituals, where individuals feel a deep connection to a higher power or a profound sense of peace.

Hypnosis

Specific State: Hypnosis is a specific type of trance that is intentionally induced by a practitioner or through self-hypnosis techniques. It involves a heightened state of suggestibility where the conscious mind is relaxed, and the subconscious mind becomes more accessible.

Purposeful Induction: Hypnosis is typically induced for specific purposes, such as therapy (hypnotherapy), pain management, behaviour modification, or relaxation.

Guided Process: During hypnosis, a hypnotist or hypnotherapist uses techniques like guided imagery, suggestions, and focused attention to lead the individual into a

hypnotic state.

Symptoms of Trance

A hypnotic trance is a specific type of trance induced intentionally through hypnosis. During a hypnotic trance, the individual enters a state of deep relaxation and focused concentration, often with the guidance of a hypnotist or through self-hypnosis techniques. In this state, the conscious mind becomes less active, allowing the subconscious mind to be more receptive to suggestions and therapeutic involvements.

The common symptoms or indicators of being in a hypnotic trance include both physical and psychological signs. Here are some of the most common symptoms:

1. Deep Relaxation:

- Muscles become very relaxed, and the body may feel heavy or limp.

- The subject might appear to be in a deeply restful state.

2. Slowed Breathing:

- Breathing becomes slow, deep, and rhythmic.

- There might be a noticeable decrease in the rate of respiration.

3. Changes in Heart Rate:

- Heart rate may slow down as the body relaxes.

- Sometimes, a slight increase can occur initially due to heightened focus.

4. Eye Fixation or Closure:

- Eyes may remain fixed on a point or close completely.

- Rapid eye movement (REM) can occur even with closed eyes.

5. Reduced Blinking:

- Blinking rate often decreases.

- Eyes may become glassy or unfocused.

6. Catalepsy:

- A limb or the entire body may become rigid and unmovable.

- Conversely, the body may also become very limp and pliable.

7. Altered Sensation:

- Subjects might feel sensations of numbness, tingling, or changes in temperature.

- Sensory perceptions can be heightened or dulled.

8. Facial Changes:

- Relaxation of facial muscles can result in a blank or serene expression.

- Jaw may become slack.

9. Swallowing and Salivation:

- There might be increased or decreased swallowing.

- Salivation rate may change.

Psychological Symptoms:

1. Heightened Focus and Concentration:

- Attention is intensely focused on the hypnotist's voice or specific thoughts.

- External distractions become less noticeable.

2. Increased Suggestibility:

- Subjects are more likely to accept and act on suggestions given by the hypnotist.

- Critical thinking and judgment are temporarily reduced.

3. Altered Time Perception:

- Time can seem to pass very quickly or very slowly.

- Subjects often lose track of time.

4. Enhanced Imagination:

- Vivid mental imagery and visualization are common.

- Subjects can experience imaginary events as if they are real.

5. Memory Changes:

- Subjects may experience temporary amnesia, forgetting details of the session.

- Memory can be enhanced or suppressed based on suggestions.

6. Emotional Changes:

- Subjects may feel detached from their surroundings.

- They might experience strong emotions or feel a profound sense of calm and peace.

7. Distorted Sensory Perception:

- Subjects might experience changes in how they perceive their senses, such as feeling like they are floating or sinking.

- They might hear, see, or feel things that are suggested by the hypnotist.

8. Automatic Movements:

- Involuntary or semi-voluntary movements, such as arm levitation or automatic writing, can occur.

- Subjects may not be consciously aware of initiating these movements.

Post-Hypnotic Symptoms:

Post-hypnotic symptoms refer to the effects and responses that occur after a hypnosis session. These symptoms can vary widely depending on the individual, the depth of the hypnotic trance, and the suggestions given during hypnosis. Understanding post-hypnotic symptoms is crucial for both practitioners and clients, as it helps to set realistic expectations and maximize the therapeutic benefits of hypnosis. Following are some common post-hypnotic symptoms:

1. Post-Hypnotic Suggestions:

- Subjects might carry out suggestions given during trance after the session ends.

- These can include changes in behaviour, thoughts, or feelings.

2. Relaxation and Calmness:

- A sense of deep relaxation and well-being can persist after the trance.

- Subjects may feel refreshed and energized.

3. Memory Recall or Amnesia:

- Subjects might remember details of the trance vividly or experience partial amnesia.

- Recall can vary based on the hypnotist's suggestions.

4. Increased Awareness and Insight:

-Clients often experience enhanced self-awareness and lead to positive changes and personal growth.

Possible Temporary Symptoms

1. Drowsiness: Some individuals might feel slightly disoriented or drowsy immediately after a hypnosis session, which typically fades quickly.

2. Memory Recall: There might be an increased ability to recall past events or memories that were previously inaccessible or unclear.

3. Mild Headaches or Light-headedness: A few people may experience mild headaches or a sense of light-headedness as they return to a fully alert state.

Levels of Hypnotic Depth (Trance)

Characteristics: The person feels relaxed and may experience minor changes in perception and awareness. They can still be easily distracted.

Symptoms: Tingling, eye closure, relaxation.

Uses: Stress relief, mild pain management, and habit control (e.g., smoking cessation).

Medium Trance (Alpha State)

Characteristics: Enhanced suggestibility, deeper relaxation, more significant changes in perception.

Symptoms: Altered sense of time, partial amnesia, and greater focus on suggestions.

Uses: Behavioural change, deeper relaxation techniques, moderate pain control.

Deep Trance (Somnambulistic State)

Characteristics: Very high suggestibility, profound changes in perception, memory and behaviour.

Symptoms: Full amnesia for the trance session, hallucinations (both positive and negative), anaesthesia.

Uses: Surgery without anaesthesia, deep psychological work, accessing repressed memories.

Scales for Measuring Hypnotic Depth

1. Stanford Hypnotic Susceptibility Scales (SHSS):

The SHSS is a set of tasks and suggestions designed to see how well someone responds to hypnosis. It categorizes people into low, medium, or high susceptibility based on their reactions to these suggestions. It helps therapists understand how deeply someone can go into a hypnotic state.

2. The Harvard Group Scale of Hypnotic Susceptibility (HGSHS):

This scale is used to test how easily a group of people can be hypnotized. It involves using standard hypnotic techniques and specific suggestions to see who responds well to hypnosis. It's often used in research to study how groups of people react

under similar hypnotic conditions.

3. Leeds Reliable Change Indicator (LRCI):

The LRCI measures changes in how susceptible someone is to hypnosis over time. It helps therapists track improvements in responsiveness with repeated hypnosis sessions. It's useful for seeing if someone becomes more or less receptive to hypnosis after multiple sessions.

4. Erickson Scale of Hypnotic Susceptibility (ESH):

Named after Milton H. Erickson, this scale focuses on how well individuals respond to personalized hypnotic techniques. It's less about standardized tasks and more about understanding each person's unique reactions to hypnosis. It's often used in therapeutic settings where customized approaches are needed.

Here are examples of the types of tasks or questions typically used in each scale to measure hypnotic depth:-

1. Stanford Hypnotic Susceptibility Scales (SHSS):

In the SHSS, individuals are presented with various suggestions or tasks to assess their responsiveness to hypnosis. Examples include:

- Imagining their arm is stiff and rigid.

- Suggesting they hear a sound that isn't actually there.

- Asking them to forget a number temporarily.

2. The Harvard Group Scale of Hypnotic Susceptibility (HGSHS):

The HGSHS is designed to measure group susceptibility to hypnosis through standardized techniques. Examples of tasks include:

- Using eye fixation to induce a hypnotic state.

- Suggesting relaxation and deepening of the trance.

- Asking participants to experience sensations like warmth or heaviness in their limbs.

3. Leeds Reliable Change Indicator (LRCI):

The LRCI tracks changes in hypnotic susceptibility over multiple sessions. Questions and tasks can include:

- Repeating tasks from previous sessions to see if responsiveness increases or decreases.

- Monitoring changes in suggestibility, such as how quickly someone relaxes or responds to suggestions after multiple sessions.

4. Erickson Scale of Hypnotic Susceptibility (ESH):

The ESH focuses on personalized responses to hypnotic techniques. Examples include:

- Tailoring suggestions based on individual preferences or experiences.

- Using metaphors or storytelling to induce trance states.

- Adjusting the pace and style of induction to match the client's responses and comfort levels.

Factors Influencing Hypnotic Depth

1. Individual Susceptibility: Some people are naturally more susceptible to hypnosis and can reach deeper trance states more easily.

2. Hypnotist Skill: The experience and techniques used by the hypnotist can significantly influence the depth of the trance.

3. Environment: A quiet, comfortable setting without distractions helps achieve deeper hypnosis.

4. Belief and Expectation: The subject's belief in the process and their expectations can affect their depth of hypnosis.

5. Practice and Repetition: Regular practice can deepen the trance state over time.

Techniques to Induce Deeper Trance

1. Progressive Relaxation: This involves guiding the individual to relax each part of their body progressively, starting from the toes or fingers and moving upward. By focusing on relaxing each muscle group, the person enters a deeper state of physical and mental relaxation, which facilitates entering trance.

2. Visualization: Using mental imagery, the hypnotist guides the subject to visualize calming scenes, peaceful environments, or scenarios that promote relaxation and focus. Visualization helps shift attention inward and enhances receptivity to hypnotic suggestions.

3. Deepening Techniques: These techniques are designed to deepen the trance state once relaxation is achieved. Examples include:

- Suggestions to "Go Deeper": Encouraging the subject to relax further and enter an even deeper state of hypnosis.

- Countdowns: Counting down from a higher number (e.g., from 10 to 1) while suggesting deeper relaxation with each number.

- Repetition of Commands: Using repeated phrases like "relax” and “deeper" or "sink further into relaxation" to reinforce the hypnotic state.

4. Fractionation: This technique involves bringing the subject in and out of trance multiple times during a session. Each time they re-enter trance, they typically go deeper than before. Fractionation can enhance responsiveness to suggestions and deepen overall hypnotic depth over the course of a session.

Risks of Hypnosis:

1. False Memories: In some cases, hypnosis can lead to the creation of false memories or distortions of actual events, especially during regression therapy or exploration of past experiences.

2. Emotional Intensity: Hypnosis may bring forth intense emotions or memories that could be distressing for the individual, particularly if they are not adequately prepared or supported.

3. Dependence: Some individuals may become overly reliant on hypnosis as a solution for their problems, potentially neglecting other necessary forms of therapy or selfcare.

4. Unintended Effects: Hypnosis can occasionally result in unplanned consequences, such as increased suggestibility to harmful suggestions or reinforcement of negative behaviours if not carefully managed.

Ethical Considerations

1. Informed Consent: Practitioners must ensure that clients fully understand the nature of hypnosis, its potential benefits, risks, and limitations before proceeding with any sessions. Informed consent ensures that clients are aware of what to expectand can make decisions based on accurate information.

2. Client Autonomy: Clients should be respected as autonomous individuals throughout the hypnosis process. They have the right to refuse suggestions, terminate sessions, or express discomfort at any time without pressure or coercion.

3. Confidentiality: Just like in other therapeutic settings, confidentiality is crucial in hypnosis. Practitioners must maintain strict confidentiality regarding the content of sessions unless legally obligated to disclose information.

4. Competence and Training: Hypnosis should only be practiced by trained professionals who adhere to ethical guidelines and possess adequate knowledge of

hypnosis techniques, psychological principles, and ethical standards.

5. Avoidance of Exploitation: Hypnosis should never be used to exploit clients or manipulate them for personal gain or entertainment purposes. Practitioners must prioritize the well-being and interests of their clients at all times.

6. Scope of Practice: Hypnosis should be used within the practitioner's scope of competence and training. Referrals should be made when issues arise that require expertise beyond the practitioner's capabilities.

BLESSINGS SCHOOL OF HYPNOSIS